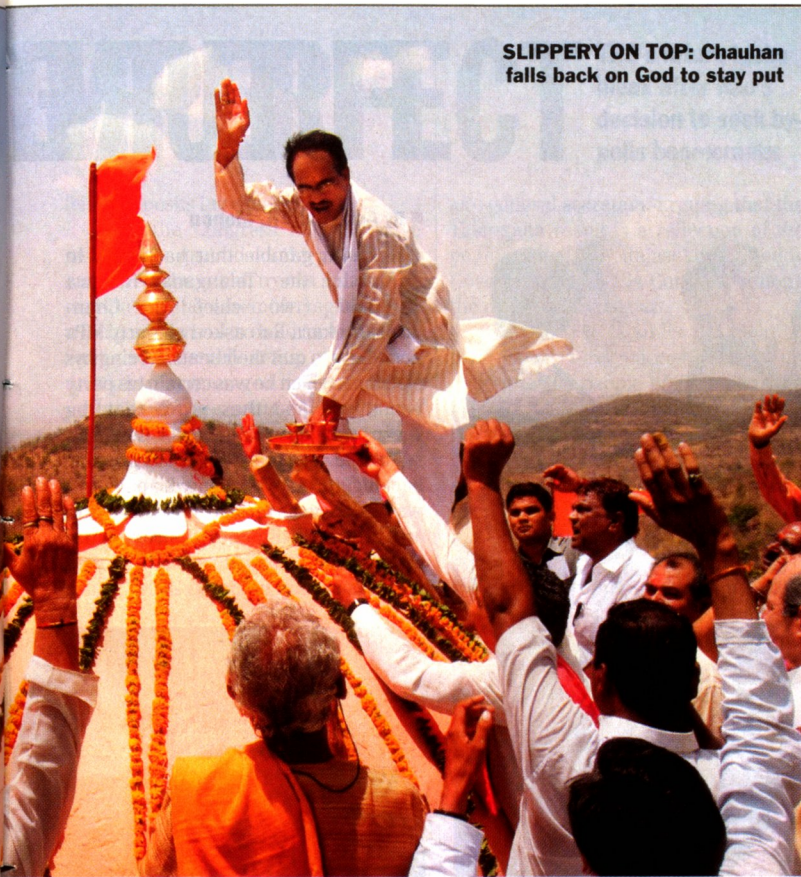


SLIPPERY ON TOP: Chauhan falls back on God to stay put



PAWAN BHAWAR

Singh Yadav. The situation is radically different in Madhya Pradesh." Many even in BJP say that the idea of Brahmin political phenomenon in the state is just a self-fulfilling prophecy, which, having come into being, is acquiring a momentum of its own.

In the Congress, Digvijay still remains the most powerful politician. No surprise then that his followers have adopted a non-cooperation policy towards the Pachouri faction. However, it is the ruling BJP which is facing the most trying time in its efforts to woo Brahmins. The party is grappling with the new-found ambition and stridency of its Brahmin leaders like Mishra, Cooperatives Minister Gopal Bhargava and Rajya Sabha member Raghunandan Sharma. But Mishra boycotted the programme attended by all the other Brahmin cabinet members like Narottam Mishra, Laxmikant Sharma, Bhargava and Ramakant Tiwari. A day after the programme, he told newsmen in Gwalior that Brahmins were being ignored by the party to the detriment of its prospects in the next elections.

The party's newly-elected Rajya Sabha member Raghunandan Sharma told another gathering of Brahmins in Babai town near the state capital that

Brahmins form the largest chunk in the list of 71 BSP candidates already selected.

ENCORE: Mayawati hopes Brahmins will flock to her as they did in UP

some segments of Gwalior-Chambal, Bundelkhand and Vindhya regions on the Uttar Pradesh border. However, they are nowhere near as numerous or widespread in Madhya Pradesh as in Uttar Pradesh. Says a member of the state BJP campaign committee, "According to our assessment, Brahmin voters can play a decisive role in at least 35 rural and 15 urban constituencies." In case of a close finish in a 230-member House, 50 seats matter a lot.

Others don't quite agree with the assessment. Says Congress's Brahmin veteran and former Assembly speaker Srinivas Tiwari, "Traditional voters of the Congress and BJP, especially Brahmins, defected to BSP because it was the strongest to counter Mulayam



SIPRA DAS

Brahmins, as long as they were devoted and committed workers of the party, would need to be assertive like Parashuram or else they would be ignored the way he was.

While BJP's Brahmin leaders fight among themselves to emerge the tallest representative of the community within the party, none has ever been a widely-acceptable Brahmin face for their own community or even sub-castes of Brahmins. The community is not a monolithic formation but is divided into numerous sub-castes that inhabit the different regions of the state and neither inter-marry, nor have a common political cause. As parties slice and dice votebanks in times of sharpening political identities, the riddle of the elusive Brahmin voter could yet prove to be the most tough to crack. ■